

FROM FIRST MARKS TO COHESIVE ESSAYS

The Progression of Writing Development — letter formation → letter–sound connection (graphophonemic awareness) → clear, cohesive writing

1

~1–3 yrs

Scribbling & Drawing

Marks record ideas; children build fine motor control, grip, and the sense that print carries meaning (Reading Rockets; Voyager Sopris). *Looks like: scribbles, drawings, full-fist grip.*

2

~3–4 yrs

Letter-Like Forms & Emerging Letter Formation

Mock letters and shapes appear; explicit, playful stroke and name-writing practice prevents bad habits later (Reading Universe; Cheyney-Collante et al., 2018). *Looks like: circles, lines, "pretend" letters.*

3

~4–5 yrs

Letter Strings

Real letters strung together without spaces or sound matches; teaching letter names AND sounds together builds alphabet knowledge (Piasta, Purpura, & Wagner, 2010). *Looks like: "TBRMSS" — uppercase strings.*

4

K–Gr. 1

Invented Spelling — The Graphophonemic Breakthrough

Letters connect to sounds; words are spelled phonetically with spaces. Adult support linking sounds to symbols predicts stronger decoding (Bindman et al., 2014). *Looks like: "I LK MI DG" (I like my dog).*

5

Gr. 1–4

Conventional Writing & Sentence Fluency

Spelling and punctuation become mostly accurate; automatic handwriting frees working memory for ideas, and sentences grow into paragraphs (Reading Rockets; Camp, 2012). *Looks like: readable sentences, simple paragraphs.*

6

Gr. 5–12+

Clear & Cohesive Essay Writing

Writers plan, draft, and revise multi-paragraph texts for real audiences using academic language and genre structures; development continues across the lifespan and follows variable paths (Bazerman et al., 2017). *Looks like: thesis-driven essays with evidence, cohesion, and voice.*

INTERVENTION STRATEGIES — High School English (Grades 9–12)

Target stage: **Stage 6, Cohesive Essay Writing** — but one classroom spans the range, so strategies scaffold down to spelling and sentence-level needs.

1. Explicit Strategy Instruction (Plan → Draft → Revise)

Model and gradually release planning routines for essays (claim, evidence, counterargument) — the most effective adolescent writing intervention (Graham & Perin, 2007).

2. Sentence Combining, Not Grammar Drills

Combine kernel sentences ("The storm hit. The power failed.") into complex ones to build the syntax cohesive essays need (Graham & Perin, 2007).

3. Mentor Texts & Genre Study

Analyze strong models of each genre so the features of academic writing — openings, transitions, cohesion — become consciously visible (Bazerman et al., 2017).

4. Frames & Scaffolds for Multilingual Learners

Temporary paragraph frames ("Although ___ argues ___, ..."), sentence starters, and transition word banks give ELs access to grade-level composition.

5. Targeted Transcription Support

Morphology-based spelling work, typing fluency, and speech-to-text for students whose transcription still steals working memory from ideas (Camp, 2012; Reading Universe).

6. Frequent Low-Stakes Writing + Formative Feedback

Journals and quick-writes with brief, criteria-based feedback; portfolios that foreground growth over time rather than one-shot grades (Camp, 2012).